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**King Wally's
'more talented'
brother ...**

**... The tragic crash.
And a passion that
can't be extinguished**

MICHAEL MADIGAN'S SPECIAL REPORT P10-11

Picture: Richard Walker

Meet Eddie, the man who could've been a King

WALLY'S 'MORE TALENTED' BRO AND THE CRASH THAT ENDED HIS CAREER

MICHAEL MADIGAN

THE two Lewis brothers took widely divergent paths through life, but football and family will always ensure Wally and Eddie are never far apart.

Wally Lewis may be considered the greatest rugby league player of all time.

But Eddie, the lesser-known Lewis, is believed by those who know him best to have once been the more talented player.

And Eddie's passion for the game hasn't dimmed in the 43 years since he last ran on to the field.

That devotion was never more evident than in the clean-up after the February floods.

Eddie, now just a month short of his 60th birthday, was working as a traffic controller near Suncorp Stadium during the flood aftermath in early March.

He spotted some rugby league memorabilia being discarded outside what was once known as Lang Park, where a statue of his brother Wally holds pride of place.

Even though the memorabilia was damaged by muddy water, Eddie saw the historic value in it and decided to rescue it for posterity.

"It was tainted by floodwater and it was all supposed to be dumped but I thought it was all pretty valuable," he said.

"There's a few old trophies and even a match program



1979, the hugely talented 17-year-old league player – who had played with the firsts rugby union team at Brisbane State High School – was involved in a horror road accident on Chambers Flat Rd on the way home from the Gold Coast.

A drunken driver ran into him and his two mates as the trio were going back to Brisbane in his little Hillman Hunter.

Eddie's injuries were too numerous to fully catalogue but, among other things, he suffered a fractured skull, depressed cheekbone, a broken jaw in seven places, five broken ribs, two collapsed lungs, a broken back, a broken pelvis and a broken left leg in three places.

The mates – Garry Bridge,

dating back to the 1920s that my mum has got and is going to try and restore.

"It's all part of history."

Eddie has some history of his own and, as painful as it's been, he's managed to transcend it, demonstrating the perseverance and endurance of the great Australian battler.

Nine days before Christmas

I was in the firsts (rugby union team) at school but always saw my future with rugby league

Eddie Lewis